crusade. In the fall of 1244, disastrous news had come from the east: Jerusalem had fallen once more into Muslim hands.

The disaster had been brought about by a complicated five-year series of events. Frederick's treaty with the sultan al-Kamil had expired in 1239; Islamic law dictated that a treaty made by Muslims with infidels could not last more than ten years. In most cases, treaties were simply renewed once per decade. But al-Kamil had died in 1238, and his two sons had battled over his empire.

The older brother, as-Salih Ayyub, triumphed (and imprisoned his rival for the rest of his life). However, the short sharp civil war had given Ayyub's uncle as-Salih Ismail, brother of al-Kamil and governor of Damascus under al-Kamil's sultancy, the opportunity to rebel. He declared himself ruler of the Syrian half of the Ayyubid empire, splitting Saladin's kingdom in half. Ismail was now the overlord of Jerusalem.

So Ayyub hired mercenaries to attack his uncle's Syrian domains, hoping to recover them for himself.

These mercenaries were wandering survivors of the Turkish kingdom of Khwarezm, destroyed by Genghis Khan in 1219. When the last Shah of Khwarezm, Jalal ad-Din, had fled into India pursued by Genghis's men, his army and family had been wiped out, but Jalal ad-Din himself had survived. He had spent the next ten years of his life waging guerrilla warfare against the Mongol conquerors, finally meeting his end at Mongol hands in a desperate mountain battle in 1231. His followers, instead of dispersing, became known as the *Khwarezmiyya*, nomadic mercenaries, claiming to preserve the last remnants of Khwarezm culture, hiring themselves out to whoever could pay.[4]

In 1244, ten thousand Khwarezmiyya, fighting on behalf of the Sultan of Egypt, swept down on Syria. On August 11, they stormed Jerusalem. They slaughtered both Muslims and Christians in the streets, broke into the Church of the Holy Sepulchre, and ripped the bones of the Crusader kings of Jerusalem from their crypts. Ayyub of Egypt claimed the city, now not much more than ruins, for his own.[5]

News of the fall had been greeted in the west with grief, and with calls for another crusade to retrieve the city. Now, recovering from his illness, Louis IX was ready to answer.

It took him three years to make the proper arrangements. He collected a special crusade tax from his subjects to pay for the expedition, and recruited French barons and their knights to join him. From the city of Genoa, he bought scores of ships; over thirty two- and three-decked sailing ships, transport galleys, war galleys. He sent provisions to Cyprus, where he intended to rendezvous with other Crusader knights; "great stacks of barrels